interesting perspective on the talks. We (the Army) wanted an early resolution, but he had another perspective. 'The longer the talks draw out,' he said, 'the better, as the positions we now hold become semi-permanent and in time, it will become the "new status quo", which was precisely what China had been doing with all its neighbours on land and maritime boundary issues. We should be prepared to continue with our forward deployment not only for this winter but for as long as it takes, even years, if necessary, as had happened in resolving the Sumdorung Chu incident of 1987, "Operation Chequerboard", which had taken years to resolve.'[21] This perspective certainly influenced the manner in which we went about creating infrastructure in preparation for a 'long haul'.

The seventh round of talks was held on 12 October, in which, taking a cue from us, the Chinese included a representative from their Ministry of Oceanic and Border Affairs. The PLA came out with a proposal for disengagement. This proposal, presented during the meeting, which carried over to 13 October, envisaged a disengagement to be carried out over three days, commencing from 14 October, barely twenty-four hours later. This once again showed the presumptuousness of their approach, that whatever they proposed would be accepted lock, stock and barrel. The proposal itself was half-baked and envisaged disengagement from the South Bank and Kailash Range first, over three days (14–16 October), then after ground verification on 17 October, disengagement on the North Bank over a similar period of three days commencing 21 October. This was totally unacceptable to us on two counts; first, it started from the South Bank (as we had anticipated) and second, the pullback they were suggesting on the North Bank was not only partial but weighted heavily in their favour and in keeping with what the NSA, Shri Ajit Doval, had highlighted. Moreover, it

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